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AI-Based Intelligent Network Intrusion Detection and Traffic Analyzer

Pramila S
Department of CSE (Data Science)
New Horizon College of Engineering
Bengaluru, India
pramila.s_ds_nhce@newhorizonindia.edu

Harshavardhan J S
Department of CSE (Data Science)
New Horizon College of Engineering
Bengaluru, India
1NH23CD206@newhorizonindia.edu

Nicale J
Department of CSE (Data Science)
New Horizon College of Engineering
Bengaluru, India
1NH23CD102@newhorizonindia.edu

Darshan Shivaji
Department of CSE (Data Science)
New Horizon College of Engineering
Bengaluru, India
1NH23CD042@newhorizonindia.edu

Srimiruthyanjayan K
Department of CSE (Data Science)
New Horizon College of Engineering
Bengaluru, India
1NH23CD169@newhorizonindia.edu

***Abstract*—Rapid advancements in computer networks and Internet-enabled services have made these systems more vulner able to cyber threats such as denial-of-service attacks, malware,phishing, and hacking. Conventional network intrusion systems that mostly use signature-based mechanisms have been found inadequate in identifying unknown and constantly evolving cyberattacks. This research paper describes a novel AI-based intelligent network intrusion detection system and traffic analyzer that makes use of machine learning techniques in order to detect cyberattacks in real time. A collection of network traffic data is first performed in a simulation environment as well as a real-time one, followed by the process of cleaning, normalization, and feature selection from the raw data. Machine learning algorithms such as Random Forest, Support Vector Machine, and Decision Tree were utilized to perform classification of network traffic between normal and malicious types. Random Forest was the model algorithm that provided more accurate predictions. The system is able to identify various types of attacks such as denial-of-service, distributed denial-of-service, brute force attacks, and unauthorized access. The web application, built using Flask framework and related frontend technologies, enables users to analyze their network traffic and display statistical information about it along with issuing alerts in case an attack is detected. The system keeps logs for further investigation and reporting purposes. According to experimental results obtained throughout the project, a high level of accuracy can be achieved in detecting network intrusions while minimizing the number of false positives.**

***Index Terms*—Intrusion Detection System (IDS), Network Security, Machine Learning, Traffic Analysis, Cybersecurity, Real Time Monitoring, Anomaly Detection, Artificial Intelligence**

I. Introduction

A. Background and Motivation

With the rapid expansion of computer networks and internet-based services, network security has become a critical concern for organizations, governments, and individuals. The increasing dependence on digital systems for communication, financial transactions, and data storage has made networks highly vulnerable to cyber attacks. According to recent studies,the frequency and sophistication of cyber threats such as denial-of-service attacks, malware, phishing, and unauthorized access have significantly increased, posing serious risks to sensitive information and system integrity. Traditional security mechanisms, which rely heavily on predefined rules and signature-based detection, are often inadequate in identifying new and evolving attack patterns. These limitations highlight the urgent need for intelligent and adaptive security systems capable of detecting both known and unknown threats in real time.

B. Limitations of Traditional Intrusion Detection Systems

Conventional Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS) are pri marily based on signature matching techniques, where known attack patterns are stored in databases and incoming traffic is compared against these signatures. While effective for detect ing previously identified threats, such systems fail to recognize zero-day attacks and sophisticated intrusion techniques that do not match existing patterns. Additionally, these systems often generate a high number of false positives and lack the capability to analyze complex network behavior. The absence of real-time analysis and adaptive learning further reduces their effectiveness in modern dynamic network environments.

C. Proposed System

This project proposes development of a machine learning based intelligent network intrusion detection and traffic analyzer that will help detect any malicious behavior by analyzing the network traffic. Data from simulated and actual networks are used to capture traffic that goes through preprocessing processes such as data cleaning, normalization, and feature extraction. Traffic data then go through the process of classification into normal and suspicious. Intrusions detected include attacks like DoS, DDoS, brute force attacks, and unauthorized access among others. Because monitoring occurs consistently, any suspicious traffic is promptly detected.

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D. Emergence of Artificial Intelligence in Cybersecurity

To address these challenges, Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Machine Learning (ML) have emerged as powerful tools in the field of cybersecurity. These technologies enable systems to learn from historical data, identify hidden patterns, and make intelligent decisions without explicit programming. Machine learning algorithms such as Decision Trees, Support Vector Machines, and Random Forest have been widely applied for intrusion detection due to their ability to classify network traffic accurately. Furthermore, AI-based systems can contin uously improve their performance by adapting to new data, making them suitable for detecting evolving cyber threats.

E. Visualization and User Interaction

The system also has a web based dashboard developed in Flask to ease the network monitoring. The network traffic, detected anomalies, and alert notifications are presented in the dashboard in an easy-to-understand visual manner. Ad ministrators can see traffic behavior, check suspicious events and keep logs for future analysis. The interactive visualization reduces the complexity of network monitoring and makes easier for users to understand security events.

F. Problem Statement and Objectives

Although significant progress has been made in cybersecu rity technologies, many network environments are still unable to detect sophisticated and fast-evolving cyber attacks. Older techniques cannot always handle high-speed traffic and zero day threats. Therefore, the aim of this work is to create a system that can automatically analyze the network traffic and detect known and unknown attacks using machine learning techniques. The study focuses on preprocessing traffic data, comparison of classification models such as Random Forest, SVM, and Decision Tree, developing a dashboard for real time monitoring, and reducing false alarms while maintaining reliable detection accuracy.

G. Significance of the Study

The study shows the significance of machine learning in improving the security of the network by incorporating automation and smart traffic analysis. The developed framework helps in decreasing the reliance on manual inspection and provides better chances of detecting any malicious activities in order to make effective management of the network. Preprocessing and feature selection have also been discussed in the study due to their significance in achieving better results through classification. Moreover, the developed system is modular and flexible, which makes it suitable for use in all kinds of network systems.

H. Novelty and Core Contribution

In summary, the novelty of this work comes from the fact that ML-based intrusion detection, traffic analysis, and visualization are implemented in the same project. Contrary to the existing systems, which mostly rely on the signatures of known attacks, the suggested algorithm uses intelligent classification methods for detecting the presence of various intrusions. By implementing the process of preprocessing, traffic classification, and data visualization, one gets a full fledged solution to monitor traffic and identify any threats on the network. The importance of the research comes from the possibility to enhance network protection since the suggested system allows identifying the potential risks faster and with less manual monitoring. As opposed to other intrusion detection solutions, this project can detect several types of attacks such as DoS attacks,DDoS attacks, brute-force attacks, and unauthorized access.

Major contributions to science made during this project were creating an intrusion detection system based on artificial in telligence algorithms, implementing and comparing three ML models, Random Forest, SVM, and Decision Tree, creating a Flask-based visualization dashboard, applying preprocessing, and creating a flexible project structure.

II. Related Work

The fast growth of the number of cyberattacks has made the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Machine Learning (ML) methods very popular in intrusion detection in computer networks. The main flaw of traditional systems was their reliance on a static set of known attacks' characteristics, which could be easily exploited by hackers who would modify their attacks or create brand new threats. Research has shown that using AI could enhance the process of detecting such threats by learning typical patterns of traffic and distinguishing between benign and malicious flows [1]. Explainable AI has emerged as one of the key issues nowadays, dealing with making intrusion detection systems more understandable for their users [1]. However, current work has revealed some problems, such as the increased need for computing resources and lower adaptability of AI solutions [2]. As to the means to address intrusion detection problem, different AI tools can be used. For example, the use of Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) helps overcome the problems associated with imbalanced datasets by creating artificial attack patterns, thus allowing models to learn how to deal with such malicious traffic [3]. In addition, AI methods applied in the context of Software-Defined Networks (SDNs) proved to be quite helpful for intrusion detection [4]. The use of advanced deep learning methods in which recurrent neural network models were enhanced by an optimization technique also helped obtain better results [5]. The interpret ability of IDS was another aspect of interest in current research. Even though complicated models might produce impressive outcomes, they remain hard to understand. It appears that hybrid approach based on ensembles, together with using XAI principles, is capable of boosting IDS per formance and making it more secure from misclassifications by significantly lowering the number of false positives [7]. Besides, interpretable machine learning in this context has put the emphasis on the need for understandable predictions that could be used by administrators in order to evaluate suspicious activity quickly and effectively [12]. The rapid spread of the IoT devices and software-defined networks brought up a range

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of new security problems. Intru sion detection systems relying on AI proved to be efficient in IoT environments, although faced such problems as heteroge neous nature of devices, limited computational resources, and emerging new types of threat [5]. One solution to the problem was developing edge-assisted intrusion detection framework that would help boost efficiency and ensure better protection in such environment [9]. Host-based intrusion detection sys tems were also developed to improve protection of the IoT architecture by ensuring higher reliability and adaptability to cyber threats [10], [11]. In addition to this, a significant problem that has arisen recently is detection of anomalies in encrypted traffic. As traditional packet inspection approaches become less efficient in this case, AI-based solutions appeared to prove useful in detecting suspicious behaviors in encrypted traffic environ ments [6]. Moreover, predictive anomaly detection approaches aimed at identifying threats in future network architectures were suggested by researchers [8]. As for now, despite many benefits offered by using AI and machine learning algorithms, there are several aspects of IDS development that can be improved. First of all, a significant problem is lack of focus not only on the detection efficiency but also on interpretability of predictions and their adaptability to new situations. Furthermore, some solutions are tailored specifically for certain network types like IoT or software defined network, which reduces the range of applicability of IDSs considerably. To address these issues, the proposed project suggests developing an AI-based Intelligent Network Intrusion Detection and Traffic Analyzer that would include such stages as preprocessing, classification of traffic with the help of machine learning algorithm, real-time monitoring, and visualization using a Flask-based dashboard.

III. Proposed Methodology

The above discussed AI Based Intelligent Network Intrusion Detection and Traffic Analyzer system has been designed on the concept of modular structure in order to make the detection process flexible and efficient. The entire system is categorized into three main modules that include Data Acquisition and Preprocessing, Machine Learning based Traffic Analysis, and Visualization and Monitoring respectively.

A. Data Acquisition and Preprocessing Module

The initial step in the framework includes gathering and preprocessing of the data to be used in the machine learning algorithm. In this regard, traffic data are acquired from both the simulated and real-world network environments through packet capture techniques and network monitoring. The gath ered data include the IP addresses, protocol used, packets' size, time stamps, and flows among others. Both normal traffic and malicious traffic samples are utilized in order to enhance the learning process of the algorithm. Preprocessing of the gathered traffic data occurs after the data acquisition process, whereby measures are undertaken to increase the quality of data and ensure consistency. Preprocessing entails the removal of any duplicate entries, normalization of numerical data, elimination of noise, and conversion of data into codes that can easily be read by the computer algorithms. Feature selection is also considered as part of data preprocessing where important traffic attributes are selected in intrusion detection.

B. Machine Learning-Based Traffic Analysis Module

After the process of pre-processing, the prepared data is used for traffic classification and threat identification. The Machine Learning algorithms like Random Forest, SVM, and Decision Tree are applied for traffic classification, which classifies traffic into normal and malicious traffic. These ML models use traffic data history to identify any pattern related to cyber-attacks on the network. Of all the models considered, the Random Forest model stands out due to its robustness, better dealing with larger data sets, and better classification. This model checks network activities regularly and identifies any suspicious activity happening in the network. Several attacks are identifiable through this model including DoS, DDoS attacks, brute force attacks, and attacks related to unauthorized access to sensitive information. Abnormal activities are detected, and alerts are issued to help in taking immediate actions to mitigate threats. The performance of the algorithm is determined through several criteria such as accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score to improve detection accuracy and minimize false positives. Fig. 1 represents the working of the designed intrusion detection system architecture.

C. Visualization and Monitoring Module

As shown in Fig. 1, the final stage of the framework focuses on monitoring and visualization. A web-based dash board developed using Flask is integrated to present network information in an understandable format. The dashboard dis plays traffic statistics, suspicious activities, and intrusion alerts, allowing administrators to monitor network conditions more efficiently. The frontend is implemented using HTML, CSS, and JavaScript to provide an interactive environment for users. Charts, tables, and visual indicators are included to sim plify traffic interpretation and anomaly tracking. In addition, detected intrusion logs are stored for future investigation, reporting, and security auditing purposes. The availability of visual monitoring helps administrators identify unusual behavior more quickly without depending only on manual inspection.

D. Modularity and Scalability

The proposed framework has been developed under the idea of modularity, which increases system flexibility and makes possible for each module to work separately without any limitations but still interact with other modules of the frame work. Such an approach facilitates making future changes, for example, adding a new approach based on machine learning technology or visualizing something extra. The proposed framework will have the opportunity to operate with any scale of networks from small local networks to larger organizational ones. To sum up, we can state that the suggested methodology incorporates traffic acquisition, smart classification, and visualization techniques into one framework for detecting

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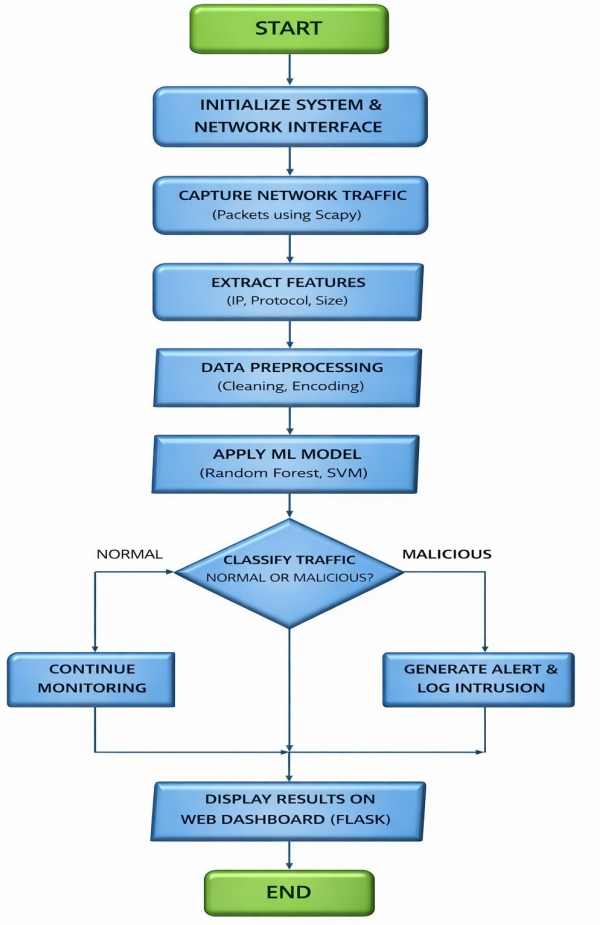


Fig. 1. Flowchart of the AI-Based Intrusion Detection System.

cyber threats. The modular construction makes the proposed framework easy to maintain, and the use of machine learning based analysis helps detect malicious traffic faster.

IV. Model Improvement and Performance Enhancement Strategies

The performance enhancement of the network intrusion detection system is highly dependent on the quality of the data, the efficiency of the model training procedure, and the ability of the system to adapt to changes in the network operation. First of all, it may be beneficial to pay close attention to the stage of feature engineering to select the most relevant characteristics of the traffic. It is possible to use features related to the size of packets, the duration of a certain traffic flow, the type of the protocol involved in communication, and interaction patterns of source and destination nodes to distinguish malicious flows from legitimate ones. The elimination of redundant and duplicated features is expected to simplify the work of the algorithm and increase its operating speed. Secondly, it may be necessary to focus on the process of hyperparameter tuning because the models used in machine learning (Random Forest, Support Vector Machine, and Deci sion Tree) have parameters that affect their performance. The application of such techniques as the grid search, randomized search, and k-fold cross-validation allows identifying optimal parameter values that help to enhance the performance of traffic classification and minimize the number of false alarms. In order to enhance intrusion detection performance, the usage of an appropriate ensemble method may prove benefi cial. Since individual classifiers might operate with different results depending on specific circumstances, their combination through such methods as bagging, boosting, or stacking will make prediction results more uniform. While the Random Forest algorithm is already based on the use of ensemble learning techniques, further development of such solutions will positively impact intrusion detection efficiency. At the same time, due to the dynamic nature of cyber at tacks, the retraining of models is essential. The employment of incremental learning will help to ensure that the models learn new traffic characteristics and maintain their high performance. Finally, the idea of adaptive monitoring should be considered. Changing sensitivity of alerts based on the changes in network activity may be helpful in minimizing the number of unnecessary alerts without reducing the efficiency of threat detection.

V. Results and Validation

Evaluations were conducted on both simulated and actual network traffic in real time on the implementation of the AI-based intelligent network intrusion detection and traffic analyzer. The purpose of conducting the evaluations was to ascertain the efficiency of the algorithms used in recognizing malicious activity as well as differentiating it from regular network activity. Evaluation metrics that have been applied include precision, accuracy, recall, and F1-score among others to determine the performance of the system under the different attack types that included DoS, DDoS attacks, brute-force attacks, and access control attacks. In the experiment part, Random Forest, SVM, and Decision Tree classifiers were applied to preprocess and analyze net work traffic. Cross-validation and repetitive tests were carried out to validate and verify the performance of the system. Real time validation also involved the application of the dashboard built using Flask web application to verify that abnormal activity was properly detected by the system. Traffic logs captured during the experiments were analyzed.

A. Comparative Analysis of Machine Learning Models

To assess the capabilities of various machine learning al gorithms, comparative analysis was performed using several criteria. Out of the applied models, Random Forest proved to have the most advanced capabilities of performing classification owing to an ensemble learning algorithm, where several decision trees work together to predict outcomes correctly.

According to the results presented in Tables I and II, the Random Forest classifier managed to deliver relatively high results in terms of accuracy on almost all criteria tested. The classifier showed excellent classification capabilities, reducing the number of errors and being capable of dealing with large data sets, thus being suitable for intrusion detection purposes.

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TABLE I
ACCURACY COMPARISON OF MACHINE LEARNING MODELS

Model	Accuracy (%)
Random Forest	97.8
SVM	94.6
Decision Tree	92.4

TABLE II
PRECISION, RECALL, AND F1-SCORE COMPARISON

Model	Precision	Recall	F1-Score
Random Forest	96.9	97.2	97.0
SVM	93.8	94.1	93.9
Decision Tree	91.5	92.0	91.7

The Random Forest technique made it possible to reduce the issue of overfitting, thus improving robustness. Similarly, SVM demonstrated relatively high capabilities of performing effective detection of malicious network traffic. Still, it should be noted that the model needed much com puting power for processing large samples. At the same time, Decision Tree was faster and easier to interpret but had slightly lower classification capabilities due to increased complexity of traffic samples. Thus, it is evident that Random Forest demonstrates better results compared to the other two models considered here.

B. Discussion, Validation, and Implications

From the above results, it can be observed that using machine learning algorithms helps significantly improve the efficiency of the intrusion detection system in recognizing any suspicious behavior within traffic better compared to other systems. The model is capable of detecting different attacks at a relatively low rate of errors compared to others. In addition, real-time monitoring using the Flask dashboard helped identify anomalies faster. From these results, it can be observed that there is practical importance of such an approach in cybersecurity where traffic needs to be monitored continuously. This approach will enable security experts to recognize any anomalies occurring within the system and respond to them accordingly. The logging process can also help in conducting investigations about past events. Although the above observations depict promising results, there are still some limitations associated with this approach. For example, sophisticated attacks, especially zero-day attacks and malicious encrypted traffic, might prove hard to detect in case their behavior is not similar to the one learned previously by the algorithm. Besides, system performance will depend on how complex traffic data is and the number of samples available.

VI. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE SCOPE

This work presents a novel AI-based approach for Intelligent Network Intrusion Detection and Traffic Analysis, designed to improve network security via machine learning, traffic analysis, and visualization. The framework involves various modules for traffic gathering, data preprocessing, classification based on machine learning techniques, and a real-time Flask based dashboard capable of tracking anomalies. The traffic classification as either normal or attack traffic (including DoS, DDoS, brute force, and unauthorized access activity) was done using three different ML techniques: Random Forest, SVM, and Decision Trees. Amongst the three techniques, Random Forest showed considerably better performance. The outcomes imply that using intelligent classification in conjunction with monitoring systems allows quicker and efficient detection of possible attacks. Being designed with a modular approach in mind, the framework is applicable in many network environments and can be easily expanded according to specific needs. However, there are issues related to detecting complex attacks, such as zero-day attacks and traffic that uses encryption. Further improvements might be introduced by applying more advanced approaches like CNN, RNN, and Transformer algorithms and retraining of the model among other improvements.

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